

Strike Fighters: Project 1

Iron Eagles

Strike Fighters closely simulates a flight model that will make a fighter pilot feel completely at home. There's still some hope for the rest of us flightless people, though.

The game puts you in the cockpits of jet fighters from the 1960's, such as the F-100 Super Sabre, F-104 Starfighter, A-4 Skyhawk and the F-4 Phantom I.

There are four modes of play—Instant Action, Single Mission, Campaign and Multiplayer. Firstly, a pilot needs to be created in the Pilot Record section. Here, you can choose the air force you're going to represent.

Once you begin flying, the full impact of the game's realism begins to hit you. Messages are constantly exchanged

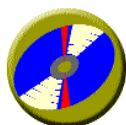


between various aircrafts and ground control. You're presented with a vast array of controls in an extremely realistic cockpit—the plane is near-impossible to control with a keyboard. The electronic tools such as radar screens, full HUD

(Heads-Up Display) and gun predictor sights *et al* are conspicuous by their absence due to the vintage nature of the planes. Thus, when we finally came across an enemy Mig, it managed to blow us into oblivion in a few seconds. Until then, we did take in quite a bit of the beautiful landscape and all the varied camera angles that the game offered. The graphics are excellent. Looking at the plane glistening in the sun is a sight you won't forget too quickly.

The gameplay and realism levels are highly customisable. Occasional crashes, and strange errors (witness a plane that never knows when to stop) mar the experience to quite an extent. Still, this simulator does its job well.

Genre: Flight Simulator ■ **Developer:** Third Wire Productions ■ **Distributor:** e-xpress Interactive Pvt Ltd ■ **Phone:** 022-28870017
Web site: www.thirdwire.com ■ **Price:** Rs 699 ■ **System requirements:** 400 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, 3D accelerator, 500 MB hard disk space, CD-ROM drive, Windows 9x\2000\Me\XP, DirectX 8.1 ■ **Rating:** ★★☆☆☆



Freelancer

All your credits are belong to us...

Circa 1998. Microsoft decides to team up with Digital Anvil to remake the veritable genius of *Elite* for the current generation of gamers. The result is *Freelancer*—a space-combat-cum-trading game as fine as its source of inspiration.

You play the role of Edison Trent, an intrepid spacecraft mechanic who decides to make his fortunes as a pilot for hire. Losing your ship, wealth and hope to an accident, you find yourself drawn into the midst of a government conspiracy.

Freelancer improves over the *Elite* series by including an engaging storyline. Follow the storyline, or wander off look-



ing for adventures. Accomplish missions, earn credits and advance in levels to gain access to better ships, bigger guns,

stronger shields, faster thrusters, and meaner enemies.

The gameplay is also simplified to a great extent—making navigation and ship control easy to learn. This makes the game immediately accessible to all and sundry. The game excels in recreating the universe in a breathtaking manner. Nebulae, incredible jump holes, brilliant stars, asteroid belts and great music; all conspire to distract you from the great gameplay.

Freelancer is truly one of the best experiences you'll ever come across. It has the 'just one more mission' attraction attached to it, that is the hallmark of all good games.

Genre: Space combat ■ **Developer:** Digital Anvil ■ **Distributor:** Sujata Electronics ■ **Phone:** 022-22885096 ■ **E-mail:** sanjiv@sujata.net
Web site: www.microsoft.com/games/freelancer ■ **Price:** Rs 1,499 ■ **System requirements:** 600 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, 16 MB video card, 900 MB hard disk space, 8X CD-ROM drive, compatible sound card ■ **Rating:** ★★★★★

